

- Set the minimum and maximum password age to an appropriate length of time—typically between 1 and 42 days. The password will expire at the end of the specified time, and the user will have to create a new password.
- Set the password history to at least six to prevent users from re-using the last six passwords. Home users need not be so stringent and can use a setting of three as well.

2.6. Use the account lock-out policy (XP Pro)

In XP Pro, a user account can be locked out after a specified number of invalid logon attempts. This can either be a genuine mistake by a user who has forgotten or mistyped the password, or an attempt by malicious software to crack the user account.

- Set the lock-out duration to 30 minutes. This will prevent users from logging into the system for 30 minutes after a specified number of invalid logon attempts. For higher levels of security, setting this to value to zero prevents users from logging in to the account right until the Administrator resets the password.
- Set the lock-out threshold to between 5 and 10 invalid logon attempts.
- Set the counter reset to between 5 and 10 minutes so that the count of the invalid logon attempts that do not reach the maximum are reset after this duration.

2.7. Mark personal folders with “Make Private” (XP Home)

Windows XP Home hides the complexity of the file sharing and permissions system of NTFS, but provides a useful feature to